

Those contradictory architects--or are they really crazy?: ARCHITECTURE

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Those contradictory architects — or are they really crazy?

DALLAS — Contradictory, or maybe just crazy, is the word for the annual convention of the American Institute of Architects concluded last week.

The first craziness was holding it in Dallas, a town that is to architecture everything that Boston is to the oil business.

The most interesting thing I discovered about Dallas is that there is a free limousine service from the downtown convention hotels out to a strip of massage parlors somewhere in the suburbs.

Just as sin is invisible, so, largely, is human life. Downtown dies at five and everyone except cops and vagrants splits in chilled cars to chilled houses and shopping strips. It's not much of a place in which to be a visitor.

The second craziness was the dominance of the convention by its Gold Medal winner, Philip Johnson.

Johnson, who at 72 is a striking fig-

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

ure, thin, witty, and full of nervous energy behind huge black-rimmed glasses, seemed to be everywhere talking about how architecture is really an art. His mistake was to do this in a metropolis (Dallas/Ft. Worth) that boasts three genuinely hideous buildings of Johnson's own design: the Amon Carter Museum of Western Art, the JFK Memorial, and an incredible superkitch disaster called Thanksgiving Square that can only have been conceived as a setting for Liberace's ascension to heaven.

In fairness, there are also the pleasant, though less conspicuous, water gardens in Fort Worth and a Dallas mansion with interesting arcaded lawns.

At a deeper level of madness, Johnson was making his pitch about art in the midst of a convention which, as usual, was ignoring the whole subject in favor of zillions of hard-nosed, wet-headed seminars on topics such as liability insurance and energy retrofits.

Johnson came to Dallas not alone but flanked, like a Norse god, by two armfuls of younger architects whom he called "these children," though most were past 40. They were, he told everyone, the best architects in the country. During the week they put on three sessions of discussion of their own work and the state of architecture in general.

For me, the tone of the whole gathering was caught best in a moment when, at the same instant, in one room the relentlessly obscure New York architect Peter Eisenman described the conflict between Euclidian and topological geometry in his latest bizarre

house while, upstairs, the AIA's president, Elmer Botsai, was gustily hosting a panel on "Avoiding Water Infiltration — the Number One Cause of Legal Action." As usual, architecture was unable to make up its mind whether it was art, technology, or business.

(To be literal about it, the ever-elusive Eisenman didn't exactly lecture but instead offered a tape of himself lecturing. Among the points he made was that the concept of absence was important to his work.)

Besides Eisenman, Johnson's "children" included Michael Graves, Charles Gwathmey, Frank Gehry, Charles Moore, Robert Stern, Stanley Tigerman and Cesar Pelli (with Richard Meier and Robert Venturi unable to come). These architects have been a kind of roadshow in the past couple of years, most appearing at last winter's "Post-Modernism" conference at Har-

vard. As they did at Harvard, they drew a huge crowd here with their discussion about the collapse of what Philip Johnson called "orthodox modernism" and its replacement by all kinds of more Romantic extremes.

Besides all this hoopla, the AIA managed to do some major business. Under pressure from the Justice Department, it voted to allow members, for the first time, to advertise. This followed a Supreme Court ruling that "commercial speech" is protected by the First Amendment. The AIA's ethics will now let an architect put "dignified" ads in print media but not radio or TV. No one was sure whether this would be enough to satisfy the feds, who are investigating the AIA and its ethics.

Also important was the vote to allow members to act as building contractors on their own designs. This issue

was so hot it had threatened to split the organization. Critics said that if it passed, it would create a conflict of interest and that owners and the public would never again trust architects, or see them as independent professionals. Supporters said if it weren't passed, architects would lose business to other designer-builders. What did pass was a compromise in which the AIA will drop the no-contracting rule as a three-year experiment while a committee monitors the results.

Boston people cropped up twice, both positively. The local society of architects co-sponsored a successful resolution to prevent the AIA from holding future conventions in states that haven't passed the Equal Rights Amendment. And former Dean Lawrence Anderson of MIT's School of Architecture and Planning got the Award for Excellence in Architectural Education.

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